Economic and Social Data Service

The Special Licence model for access to more detailed micro data

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Introduction

- The Special Licence is a new initiative allowing access to a richer source of UK survey data than previously available

- Initiated in a climate of
  - increased caution regarding data confidentiality
  - the requirement that government material be made more readily accessible

Background to the data

- The UK Office for National Statistics is a major and regular supplier of important data series, such as the Labour Force Survey
- These large-scale government datasets are collected to inform and develop government policy
- Contain wealth of information for researchers within many fields and subject areas

Background to the data continued

- High quality, well-documented, nationally representative with large samples, with some running for many years

- Fully anonymised and certain variables, particularly those relating to geography, may be suppressed or aggregated to minimise disclosure risk

More detailed data – needs and risks

- Research need for more detailed data, in particular geography
- More detail increases the risk of intentional or inadvertent data disclosure
- "The National Statistician will set standards for protecting confidentiality, including a guarantee that no statistics will be produced that are likely to identify an individual unless specifically agreed with them."

Access to data

- Access to data requires registration
- Although users agree to terms and conditions, including not to identify individuals, there was concern about researchers gaining access to more detailed data in the usual way
- Some data were withdrawn by ONS
- Talk of data being made available in safe-settings

Development of the Special Licence

- Meetings held between UKDA, ONS and ESDS Government
- Examined existing safeguards
- Produced a 'Special Licence' to facilitate access to more detailed data
- Developed a guide to good practice
- Researchers are now able to apply for access to data that include lower level geographical identifiers

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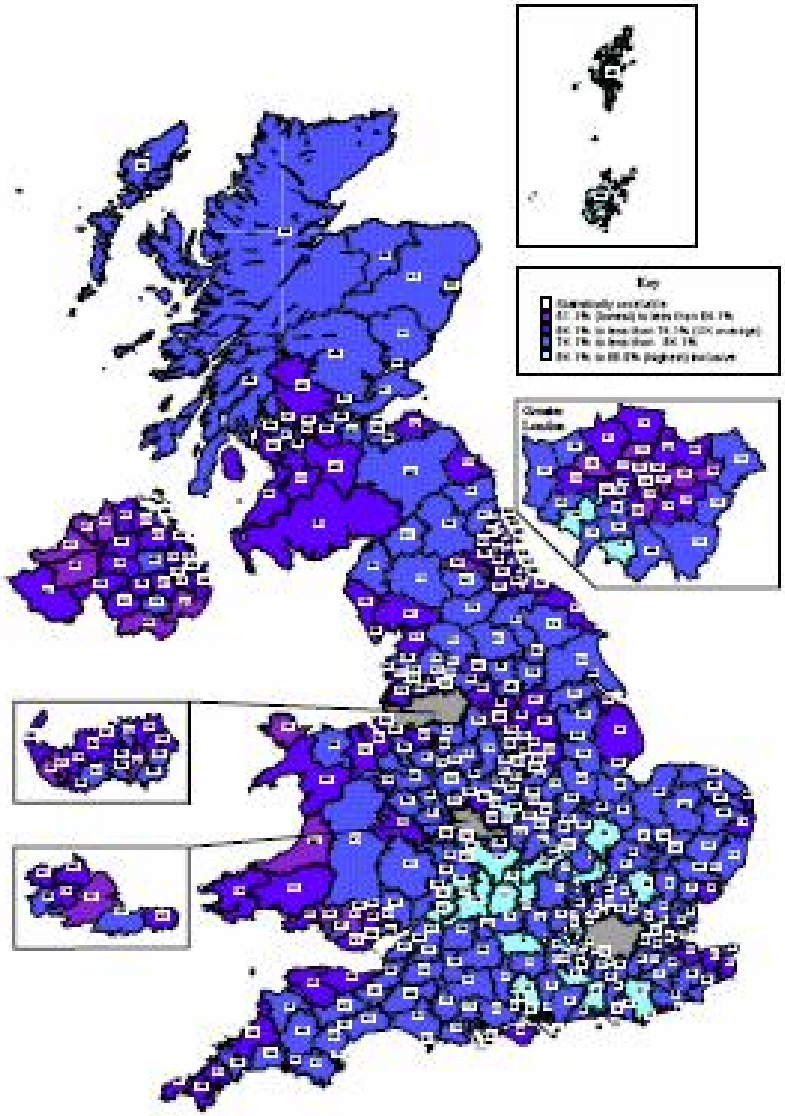
Geography



The End User Licence

- To preserve the confidentiality of individuals, households, or organisations
- To supply the bibliographic details of any published work
- Keep means of access secure
- To abide by any ‘further conditions’
- Breach will lead to termination of access

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The Special Licence

- ‘Further condition’ of the EUL
- Signed by research team (each member must be registered), ONS, UKDA
- Also signed by a departmental head, chair of ethics committee, head of division
- Requires –
  - description of intended statistical use of data
  - Justification for access to more detailed data

Special Licence continued..

Clauses on –

- standards and methods for disclosure control for any outputs
- Right of depositor to screen outputs
- Data and site security
- Data destruction
- Sanctions

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Guide to Good Practice: micro data handling and security

- Guidance on handling standard and SL versions of data
- avoiding inadvertent statistical disclosure
- storing and accessing data securely
- how to permanently destroy copies of data
- institutional responsibilities, including compliance with security standards

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The Special Licence data

- A number of ONS datasets are now available under a Special Licence -
  - Annual Population Survey
  - Labour Force Survey
  - 2001 Census data
- ONS intends to deposit standard and SL versions of all their social survey datasets
- A number of other depositors will also be using this initiative

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